

RPOS 102: Comparative and International Politics

University at Albany, SUNY | Department of Political Science

Version: August 23, 2026

This syllabus should be read together with the separate Course Schedule and Required Readings, which forms part of the course syllabus. Detailed instructions for major assignments appear in the appendices.

Course Information

Course Number	RPOS 102
Course Title	Comparative and International Politics
Department	Political Science, Rockefeller College of Public Affairs & Policy
Section	0001
Term	Fall 2026
Credit Hours	3
Course Dates	August 24 - December 7, 2026
Meeting Days/Time	Mondays and Wednesdays, 6:00-7:20 p.m. (80 minutes each; 160 minutes/week)
Location	Pine Bush 158
Prerequisites	None
General Education	Social Sciences (DP-SOCSCI)

Instructor Information

Instructor	Qiang (Steven) Wu, Ph.D.
Email	swu26@albany.edu
Office	Humanities B16
Office Hours	Friday, 12:45-2:45 p.m., and by appointment
Course Website	Brightspace

Formal Catalog Description

The characteristics and development of statehood and power; conditions of stability; constitutions and the comparative political processes; the international order and the nation-state system.

Students may receive credit for only one version of RPOS 102. (UAlbany Undergraduate Bulletin)

Course Overview and Goals

Politics is fundamentally concerned with power: who has it, where it comes from, how it is exercised, how it is challenged, and how it is constrained.

This course introduces students to comparative politics and international relations through four dimensions of political power: (I) Political Power and Legitimacy; (II) Economic Power; (III) Military Power; and (IV) Institutional Power.

Rather than treating comparative politics and international relations as unrelated subjects, the course examines questions that connect politics within countries to politics among countries. Why do people obey governments? Why do some governments rely on repression while others rely more on consent? Do markets constrain governments, or can governments shape markets? Does trade create cooperation or dependence? Why do wars occur even when war is costly? Do alliances make countries safer or create new risks? Do institutions constrain powerful actors, or do powerful actors shape institutions?

Throughout the semester, students will encounter competing perspectives rather than a single political viewpoint. We will compare democratic and authoritarian perspectives, market-oriented and state-centered approaches, left and right perspectives, realist and liberal arguments, and competing explanations for major political outcomes. The goal is not to tell students what political conclusions they should hold, but to help them identify arguments, understand their assumptions, compare explanations, evaluate evidence, and develop evidence-based arguments of their own.

Course Learning Outcomes

- Identify major theories, concepts, and substantive issues in comparative politics and international relations.
- Distinguish political, economic, military, and institutional forms of power.
- Apply political science concepts to historical and contemporary political events.
- Compare competing political arguments and explanations.
- Identify causal relationships proposed in political arguments and evaluate the evidence offered for them.
- Develop a clear thesis and use evidence to support it in an introductory research paper.
- Identify at least one plausible alternative explanation for a political outcome.
- Communicate political arguments through discussion, simulation, writing, and oral presentation.

How We Will Learn: Discuss, Debate, Draft

DISCUSS: Class discussions, small-group exercises, current-event applications, and direct dialogue with guest scholars. Discussion means engaging arguments and evidence, not simply stating an opinion.

DEBATE: Four Strategic Competition Game simulations. Students will work in four simulation teams; each team participates once as a Host and once as a Guest. Detailed instructions are in Appendix A.

DRAFT: An individual research project developed through a research presentation, feedback, revision, and a final 4-5 page paper. Detailed instructions are in Appendices B and C.

Required Materials and Reading Expectations

There is no required textbook.

The reading list emphasizes accessible books and book chapters, essays, long-form journalism, policy materials, primary documents, and selected political science research appropriate to an introductory course.

See the separate Course Schedule and Required Readings for all dates, readings, quizzes, simulations, Forum sessions, and assignment deadlines.

Assignments and Grade Distribution

Assignment	Weight
Participation - DISCUSS	10%
Quizzes	15%
Midterm Exam	20%
Strategic Competition Game - DEBATE	20%
Research Project - DRAFT	25%
Research Presentation	10%
Total	100%

Letter Grade Policy

Final numerical averages will be converted to UAlbany letter grades as follows:

A	93-100	A-	90-92.99	B+	87-89.99	B	83-86.99
B-	80-82.99	C+	77-79.99	C	73-76.99	C-	70-72.99
D+	67-69.99	D	63-66.99	D-	60-62.99	E	Below 60

Participation - DISCUSS (10%)

Students are expected to attend class prepared to participate in lectures, discussions, small-group activities, Forum sessions, simulations, and research presentations. Participation is evaluated based on preparation, engagement, listening, contribution to group activities, and quality of reasoning.

During class discussions, I will normally ask for volunteers first. To ensure that everyone has opportunities to participate, I may occasionally use an R program to randomly select a student if no one volunteers or if discussion is being dominated by the same participants. If selected, you may make a good-faith attempt, invite a classmate to help, or ask to pass on that particular question. You are not expected to provide a complete or perfect answer.

Quizzes (15%)

There will be five quizzes, each worth 3% of the course grade. Quizzes may include multiple-choice questions, concept identification, and short applications. All quizzes will be administered through Brightspace and require Respondus LockDown Browser. Their purpose is to encourage regular engagement with important course concepts rather than memorization of minor details.

Technology requirement for quizzes: Students should install and test Respondus LockDown Browser before the first quiz. If you have difficulty installing or running Respondus LockDown Browser, contact the UAlbany ITS Service Desk at askIT@albany.edu or 518-442-3700, or submit a support ticket through ITS. Brightspace also provides 24/7 student technical support through the chat icon inside Brightspace.

Midterm Exam (20%)

There will be one in-class midterm examination. It will assess understanding of major concepts, readings, lectures, and the ability to apply or compare political arguments. The exam may include multiple-choice questions, concept identification, and short analytical responses. There is no final examination.

Strategic Competition Game - DEBATE (20%)

Students will work in four simulation teams of approximately 3–4 students. The course includes four simulations. Each team—and therefore each student—will participate in two simulations during the semester: once as a Host and once as a Guest. The 20% Strategic Competition Game grade consists of the Host Team's Issue Background Brief (4 points), the Host simulation performance (8 points), and the Guest simulation performance (8 points). During the two simulations in which their team is not serving as Host or Guest, students will participate as audience members, stakeholders, advisers, countries, or other relevant actors. See Appendix A for complete instructions and the grading rubrics.

Research Project - DRAFT (25%)

Each student will complete a short individual research project on a question related to comparative or international politics. The project includes two one-page checkpoints (5% each) and a final 4-5 page research paper (15%). This is an introductory analytical paper, not a graduate-style research article. See Appendix B for complete instructions and the grading rubric.

Research Presentation (10%)

Before submitting the final paper, every student will present a working version of the research project to the class, at the research conferences during the final weeks of the semester. Each student will have approximately 20 minutes including questions and feedback. Students should use the feedback to revise the final paper. See Appendix C for complete instructions and the grading rubric.

The Forum on the United States, China, and the World Order

At selected points during the semester, the class will host sessions of *The Forum on the United States, China, and the World Order*, an initiative created by the instructor while teaching at Texas A&M University. Since its creation, the Forum has been held six times, bringing scholars into the classroom to present current research and engage directly with students. The Forum

allows students to encounter political science as an active research enterprise and to ask questions about substantive politics, research design, evidence, and the research process.

Fall 2026 Forum Speakers

Dr. Xiaonan Wang - Baruch College, City University of New York (CUNY)

Dr. Khang Vu - Boston College

Undergraduate Research Journal on the United States, China, and the World Order

Selected outstanding student research may be invited for further revision and possible publication in the *Undergraduate Research Journal on the United States, China, and the World Order*, an initiative created by the instructor while teaching at Texas A&M University. Since its creation, the Journal has published two issues featuring student research on topics related to the United States, China, and the changing world order. Up to four papers from this course that are relevant to the Journal's theme may be selected for further revision and possible publication. Publication is voluntary, requires the student's permission, and is separate from the calculation of the course grade.

Announcements and Email

Announcements posted on Brightspace will be the primary means of broadcast communication for this course. Students are responsible for checking Brightspace and their UAlbany email regularly for course announcements, schedule changes, assignments, and other important information.

When contacting the instructor by email, please use your UAlbany email account whenever possible and begin the subject line with "RPOS 102," followed by the reason for the message (for example, "RPOS 102 - Question about Research Project").

Course-Specific Late Work Policy

Unless an extension has been approved or the absence is excused under University policy, late assignments will normally lose 10 percentage points for each calendar day after the deadline. Work submitted as approved makeup work for an excused absence is not considered late. Students should contact the instructor as early as possible when emergencies or unavoidable conflicts arise.

- After the deadline but before one full day has passed: maximum 90%.
- After one full day but before two days: maximum 80%.
- After two full days but before three days: maximum 70%.
- After three full days but before four days: maximum 60%.
- After four days: the assignment normally receives no credit unless an exception has been approved.

Generative Artificial Intelligence

The purpose of this course is to develop students' own abilities to read, reason, research, discuss, and communicate political arguments. Unless an assignment explicitly states otherwise, generative AI tools may not be used to produce substantive text, analysis, citations,

presentation slides, quiz answers, or exam answers submitted for credit. When AI use is explicitly permitted, students remain responsible for verifying factual claims and citations and for following any disclosure requirements in the assignment instructions.

University Policies and Resources

The following language is drawn from the University's 2026 syllabus policy and resource materials.

Incomplete Grades Policy

University guidelines regarding incomplete grades are available at:

<https://www.albany.edu/undergraduateeducation/grading.php>

Reasonable Accommodations for Students with Documented Disabilities

We are committed to providing an accessible learning environment for all students. This includes students with physical, sensory, medical, cognitive, learning, mental health, and other disabilities. If you have, or think you may have a disability, please contact Disability Access and Inclusion Student Services (DAISS) by emailing daiss@albany.edu or calling 518-442-5501. DAISS staff will explain the documentation and registration process, and set you up with an appointment. Once you have completed registration, you will be provided with a letter to inform your instructors that you are a student with a disability registered with DAISS, and which lists the recommended reasonable accommodations for your courses.

Absence Due to Religious Observance

Students are excused, without penalty, to be absent because of religious beliefs, and will be provided equivalent opportunities for make-up examinations, study, or work requirements missed because of such absences. Students should notify the instructor of record in a timely manner, and the instructor will work directly with students to accommodate religious observances. Online courses will not schedule any assignment deadlines on religious holidays.

Academic Integrity and Conduct

Students participating in this course must conform to University academic integrity expectations and regulations.

Undergraduate Bulletin: https://www.albany.edu/undergraduate_bulletin/regulations.html

University Libraries: [Practicing Academic Integrity](#)

Course-specific standards for collaboration, citation, and the use of artificial intelligence are described elsewhere in this syllabus and in individual assignment instructions.

Attendance and Timely Compliance with Course Requirements

Students are expected to attend all classes and examinations and to complete all course requirements on time. Instructors may include attendance and/or participation as part of graded work in a course, and may impose appropriate penalties for missed or late work.

Instructors may, at their discretion, excuse a student's absence from class and allow the submission of late work in cases of emergency or legitimate, unavoidable scheduling conflicts. Students must inform instructors at the earliest possible moment when such situations arise, and instructors may ask students for verifying documentation.

The Office of the Vice Provost and Dean for Undergraduate Education will officially notify instructors of their responsibility to provide academic accommodations only in cases in which the absence exceeds one calendar week or when a student has missed a major exam or assignment, and only upon the presentation of verifying documentation by the student. In all other cases, instructors must use their best judgment in deciding whether and how to accommodate student absences, and in asking for and evaluating supporting documentation. Disagreements between instructors and students in these cases will be adjudicated through the applicable school or college grievance process, beginning with the applicable department chair. Excused absences generally fall into three categories:

1. medical care, tragedy, or emergency
2. participation in intercollegiate athletics
3. religious observance

It is the student's responsibility to provide sufficient documentation to support any request. Fraudulent excuses are violations of academic integrity and as such are grounds for disciplinary action.

Title IX Statement

Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 is a federal civil rights law that prohibits discrimination on the basis of sex in federally funded education programs and activities.

The SUNY-wide Sexual Violence Prevention and Response Policies prohibit offenses defined as sexual harassment, sexual assault, intimate partner violence (dating or domestic violence), sexual exploitation, and stalking. The SUNY-wide Sexual Violence Prevention and Response Policies apply to the entire University at Albany community, including students, faculty, and staff of all gender identities. The University at Albany provides a variety of resources for support and advocacy to assist individuals who have experienced sexual offenses.

Confidential support and guidance can be found through the Counseling Center (518-442-5800), the University Health Center (518-442-5454), and the Interfaith Center (518-489-8573).

Individuals at these locations will not report crimes to law enforcement or university officials without permission, except for in extreme circumstances, such as a health and/or safety emergency. Additionally, the Advocates at the University at Albany's Advocacy Center for Sexual Violence are available to assist students without sharing information that could identify them (518-442-CARE).

Sexual offenses can be reported non-confidentially to the Title IX Coordinator within The Office for Equity and Compliance (518-442-3800, Building 25, Room 117) and/or the University Police Department (518-442-3131).

Please note, faculty members are considered "responsible employees" at the University at Albany, meaning that they are required to report all known relevant details about a complaint of sexual violence to the University's Title IX Coordinator, including names of anyone involved or present, date, time, and location. In case of an emergency, please call 911.

Basic Needs

It is difficult to succeed academically if you don't have enough to eat, a safe place to live and sleep, or are struggling with an unforeseen emergency. Knowing the resources available on your campus to help you succeed is key! If you need help meeting these or other basic needs, please seek assistance from Supplemental Support Services in the Dean of Students Office.

View the basic needs assistance offerings at <https://www.albany.edu/dean-students/supplemental-support-services>. While you're there, see the variety of helpful services available to you at the Dean of Students at <https://www.albany.edu/dean-students>. Resources and reporting links can be found on both of these websites.

A detailed two-page UAlbany campus resource guide, including academic support, food assistance, health services, transportation, and QR codes for direct access, is reproduced as Appendix D.

Appendix A - Strategic Competition Game

I. Overview

The Strategic Competition Game is a simulation-based exercise designed to help students apply course concepts to real political problems. Four games will be held during the semester, one connected to each major unit of the course. Students will work in four simulation teams of approximately 3-4 members. Each team—and therefore each student—will participate in two simulations during the semester: once as a Host and once as a Guest. In the other two games, team members participate as audience members, stakeholders, advisers, governments, or other relevant actors.

II. Team Formation and Leadership

Simulation teams will be formed during the first class meeting. Each team should select one team leader from among its members and inform the instructor of its choice.

The team leader will serve as the primary point of contact between the team and the instructor and will help coordinate communication, preparation, division of responsibilities, and submission of team materials. The team leader is a coordinator rather than the sole person responsible for the team's work; all members are expected to contribute substantively to preparation and participation.

Team membership will normally remain the same throughout the four-game simulation sequence so that each team can serve once as Host and once as Guest under comparable conditions. The instructor may adjust team membership, leadership, or the rotation if enrollment or other circumstances require it.

III. Team Rotation

Game	Host	Guest	Other Teams
1 - Political Power	Team A	Team B	Audience / stakeholders
2 - Economic Power	Team C	Team D	Audience / stakeholders
3 - Military Power	Team B	Team A	Audience / stakeholders
4 - Institutional Power	Team D	Team C	Audience / stakeholders

IV. Host Team Responsibilities

- Develop or refine a topic within the assigned course unit, subject to instructor approval.
- Prepare a 1-2 page Issue Background Brief that establishes the factual setting, key actors, stakes, and relevant constraints. The Issue Background Brief is worth 4 points of the 20-point Strategic Competition Game grade.
- Submit the Issue Background Brief at least seven days before the simulation so the Guest Team and class can prepare.
- Present a coherent position, analysis, or strategy and respond to the Guest Team and audience questions.

V. Guest Team Responsibilities

- Research the issue independently after receiving the Host Team's background brief.
- Represent an opposing or alternative actor, perspective, or strategy.
- Challenge the Host Team with evidence and course concepts rather than merely disagreeing.
- Respond to questions and revise or defend the team's strategy during the simulation.

VI. Possible Simulation Formats

Depending on the scenario, the Host and Guest teams may represent opposing states, competing domestic political parties or groups, or contrasting policy positions within the same government or institution.

- Political power and legitimacy: a domestic political scenario involving governments and opposition groups, competing parties, political participation, legitimacy, or alternative institutional arrangements.
- Economic power and statecraft: a bargaining scenario involving sanctions, trade, technology, aid, development finance, or economic policy, with teams representing either different states or competing domestic political positions.
- Military power and security: a crisis, war, or security scenario involving deterrence, military strategy, alliances, escalation, burden sharing, or crisis management. Teams may represent opposing states or competing domestic policy positions over how the state should respond.
- Institutional power: a Model UN, legislative, constitutional, or other institutional negotiation in which actors bargain over rules, resolutions, collective action, institutional design, or cooperation.

VII. Typical 80-Minute Process

Activity	Time
Scenario introduction	5 min
Host presentation	15 min
Guest presentation	15 min
Direct debate / rebuttal	10 min
Audience or stakeholder questions	10 min
Negotiation / revised positions	10 min
Closing statements and audience evaluation	5 min
Instructor debrief	10 min

The exact sequence may vary by simulation format.

VIII. Thinking Points for Producing the Issue Background Brief

Context: International situation, domestic political pressures, economic conditions, public opinion, and military or institutional constraints.

Decision Points: Initial response options, escalation/de-escalation choices, public communication, coalition building, and alliance management.

Resources: Military capability, economic leverage, information, legitimacy, diplomatic capital, institutional rules, and time.

Stakeholders: Domestic constituencies, allies, opponents, firms, social groups, international organizations, and affected third parties.

IX. Grading (20 Points Total)

Component	Points
Host Team Issue Background Brief	4
Host simulation performance	8
Guest simulation performance	8
Total	20

Issue Background Brief rubric (4 points):

Criterion	Points
Factual accuracy and context	1.5
Key actors, stakes, and constraints	1.0
Relevance and application of course concepts	1.0
Organization and sources	0.5

Host and Guest simulation performance rubric (8 points each):

Criterion	Points
Preparation and factual accuracy	2.0
Application of course concepts	2.0
Argument and strategic reasoning	1.5
Responsiveness to counterarguments/questions	1.0
Organization and communication	1.0
Team participation and time management	0.5

The Issue Background Brief and simulation performance grades are normally shared by the team, but the instructor may adjust an individual student's score when there is clear evidence of substantially unequal participation.

Appendix B - Research Project and Final Paper

I. Purpose

This is an introductory political science research project. The goal is to practice a basic analytical sequence: Question -> Thesis -> Evidence -> Conclusion. The project is intentionally short and does not require a graduate-style literature review, original dataset, advanced statistical analysis, or a publishable research design.

II. Choosing a Research Question

A good project asks a focused explanatory question. Comparison is encouraged but not required. A focused single-case question is acceptable with instructor approval.

Better: Why did Country A respond differently from Country B to the same economic pressure?

Too broad: The history of democracy in Country A.

III. Checkpoint 1 - Question, Puzzle, and Preliminary Sources (5%)

Maximum: one page, plus a short source list. Students submit the research question, a brief explanation of why it is interesting, the cases or outcome they plan to study, a preliminary answer or expectation if they have one, and at least three preliminary credible sources. This checkpoint is designed to make sure the project is focused and feasible.

IV. Checkpoint 2 - Thesis, Alternative, Evidence, and Outline (5%)

Maximum: one page. Students submit a tentative thesis, one plausible alternative explanation, the main evidence they expect to use, and a short outline of the final paper. This is a research plan, not a separate essay.

V. Final Research Paper (15%)

Length: 4-5 double-spaced pages, excluding references. Use 12-point Times New Roman, one-inch margins, and APSA author-date citations unless the instructor approves another consistent citation style. Students should use at least four credible sources, including at least two scholarly or course-approved research sources when appropriate.

A typical paper should contain:

1. Introduction: Introduce the political question or puzzle, explain why it matters, and state the main answer or thesis.

2. Argument and Alternative Explanation: Explain the main argument and briefly identify at least one plausible competing explanation. A separate formal literature-review section is not required.

3. Evidence and Analysis: Use evidence to evaluate the argument. The paper should do more than describe events; it should explain how the evidence supports, qualifies, or challenges the thesis and alternative explanation.

4. Conclusion: Answer the research question, summarize what the evidence suggests, and acknowledge an important limitation or uncertainty.

VI. Final Paper Rubric

Criterion	Weight
Research question and thesis	20%
Argument and alternative explanation	20%
Evidence and analysis	30%
Organization and clarity	20%
Sources and citations	10%

VII. Academic Support

Students are encouraged to use the UAlbany Writing Center and Learning Commons while developing the project. See Appendix D for campus resource information and QR codes.

Appendix C - Research Presentation

I. Purpose

The research presentation gives students an opportunity to present their **working research project before the final paper is completed**. Students should use questions and feedback from the class to refine their argument, evidence, and analysis and to improve the final paper.

II. Format

Each student has approximately 20 minutes, including questions and feedback. A suggested structure is:

Component	Approx. Time
Research question / puzzle	2-3 min
Thesis and alternative explanation	3-4 min
Evidence and analysis	7-8 min
Preliminary conclusion	2 min
Questions and feedback	4-5 min

Presentation slides should be submitted to Brightspace by **11:59 p.m. on the day before the student's scheduled presentation**. The presentation order will follow the **order of students' names on the official class roster**.

III. Presentation Rubric

Criterion	Weight
Clarity of question and thesis	25%
Use of evidence and analysis	30%
Organization and communication	20%
Engagement with alternative explanation	15%
Response to questions	10%

Appendix D - UAlbany Campus Resources to Assist Students with Basic Needs

The following two pages reproduce the 2026 UAlbany student-friendly campus resource guide provided for course syllabi. The QR codes and University formatting are preserved.

UAlbany Campus Resources to Assist Students with Basic Needs

*This **non-exhaustive** list of resources can help students navigate support for basic needs at UAlbany.*

	Description	Location	Website
Financial Matters			
Student Emergency Fund	Provides financial support to students facing an emergency that may otherwise result in their leaving school.		
Campus Gold	An advance of up to \$650 per semester, available to any student upon request, to use at retail dining venues, vending machines, and AcaDamien's Bookstore.	<i>Requested via the ID Card portal</i>	
Student Financial Services	Campus hub for navigating and accessing support for financial aid matters (gift and self-help aid, FAFSA, etc.) and student accounts (billing, e-Pay, residency, etc.).	Campus Center G26	
Academic Support			
Disability Access & Inclusion Student Services (DAISS)	Campus hub for providing students with reasonable academic accommodations.	Campus Center 137	
The Learning Commons	Campus hub for navigating and accessing tutoring services (peer-to-peer, online, and departmental) and supplemental instruction.	Beneath the University Library	
The Writing Center	Campus hub for accessing peer assistance with academic writing, career and professional writing (personal statements, resumes, etc.), personal writing, and more.	Humanities 140	
Food, Clothing & Technology			
Purple Pantry	Provides non-perishable and frozen food, fresh produce, and basic toiletries to students in need.	Campus Center 329	
Purple Threads	Service that offers free professional clothing for students (e.g., for headshots or job interviews).	Campus Center 323	

Microsoft 365 Apps (aka Microsoft Office)	The suite of Microsoft Office apps that students can download for free on their personally owned devices.		
Mental and Physical Health			
Five Quad	NYS-certified ambulance agency operated by UAlbany students, providing free Basic Life Support to students 24/7 during the fall and spring semesters.	Phone number: 518-442-5555	
Student Health Services	On-site and virtual medical care.	Behind Dutch Quad	
Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS)	Mental health care, with services including but not limited to individual counseling, group counseling, assessment and testing, and psychiatric services.	Behind Dutch Quad	
Middle Earth	Students trained by mental health professionals to help their peers address common concerns many college students face via an anonymous hotline available during evenings and on weekends.	Phone number: 518-442-5777	
TimelyCare	Virtual platform with free 24/7 medical and mental health services for students.		
Transportation			
Mass Transit	UAlbany and CDTA buses, including Northway Xpress and STAR Services, are free to all students.		

RPOS 102: Course Schedule and Required Readings

Fall 2026 | Mondays & Wednesdays, 6:00-7:20 p.m.

Companion to the RPOS 102 Course Syllabus | Version: August 23, 2026

This schedule forms part of the course syllabus. The instructor may make reasonable adjustments to reflect the pace of the course, current events, or guest-speaker availability. Changes will be announced through Brightspace.

Extended readings: Some class meetings include optional extended readings related to that day's topic. These readings are not required unless the instructor specifically announces otherwise; they may be used if time permits or by students who want to explore a topic further.

Introduction - What Is Power?

Mon Aug 24 | Introduction: Politics, Comparison, and Power

Reading / Activity: No required reading

Due / Notes: Simulation teams formed; each team selects a team leader and informs the instructor.

Wed Aug 26 | What Is Power? Hard Power and Soft Power

Reading / Activity: Joseph S. Nye Jr. (1990), "Soft Power," Foreign Policy 80 (entire article).

Part I - Political Power and Legitimacy

Mon Aug 31 | The State, Authority, and Legitimacy

Reading / Activity: Max Weber (1919), "Politics as a Vocation," pp. 2-17 of the assigned PDF. We will examine Weber's conception of the state and political power, the sources of legitimate authority, and the organization of political domination.

Extended reading (optional): Daniel L. Byman and Kenneth M. Pollack (2001), "Let Us Now Praise Great Men: Bringing the Statesman Back In," International Security 25(4): 107-120 and 133-146.

Wed Sep 2 | Democracy: What Is It?

Reading / Activity: Kenneth Roth (2021), "The Age of Zombie Democracies," Foreign Affairs (entire article).

Extended reading (optional): Philippe C. Schmitter and Terry Lynn Karl (1991), "What Democracy Is ... and Is Not," Journal of Democracy 2(3) (entire article).

Mon Sep 7 | NO CLASS - Labor Day

Reading / Activity: Classes suspended.

Wed Sep 9 | Democracy, Authoritarianism, and Regime Change

Reading / Activity: Thomas Carothers (2002), "The End of the Transition Paradigm," Journal of Democracy 13(1) (entire article).

Due / Notes: Quiz 1

Mon Sep 14 | Political Participation and Civil Society

Reading / Activity: Robert D. Putnam (1995), "Bowling Alone: America's Declining Social Capital," *Journal of Democracy* 6(1): 65-78 (entire article).

Wed Sep 16 | Repression, Co-optation, and Legitimation

Reading / Activity: Johannes Gerschewski (2013), "The Three Pillars of Stability: Legitimation, Repression, and Co-optation in Autocratic Regimes," *Democratization* 20(1): 13-38 (entire article).

Due / Notes: Game 1 Host Team Issue Background Brief due (4 points).

Mon Sep 21 | Civil Society, Interest Groups, and Social Power

Reading / Activity: Larry Diamond (1994), "Rethinking Civil Society: Toward Democratic Consolidation," *Journal of Democracy* 5(3) (entire article).

Due / Notes: Quiz 2

Wed Sep 23 | STRATEGIC COMPETITION GAME 1 - Political Power and Legitimacy

Reading / Activity: No new academic reading.

Due / Notes: Team A Host / Team B Guest

Mon Sep 28 | DRAFT LAB - How Political Scientists Ask Questions

Reading / Activity: William Roberts Clark (2020), "Asking Interesting Questions," in *The SAGE Handbook of Research Methods in Political Science and International Relations*. Read from the beginning of the chapter through the "Summary" section; stop before "Practices that encourage good question asking." We will use Clark's five questions to develop and evaluate research questions for the individual research project.

Extended reading (optional): Dino Bozonelos, Julia Wendt, and Masahiro Omae (2022), "2.1: The Scientific Method and Comparative Politics" (entire assigned section).

Wed Sep 30 | THE FORUM - Dr. Xiaonan Wang (Baruch College, CUNY)

Reading / Activity: Preparation reading to be selected with the speaker. Topic: China's global economic engagement and public opinion.

Fri Oct 2 | No class - assignment deadline

Reading / Activity: No new reading.

Due / Notes: Checkpoint 1 due, 11:59 p.m.

Part II - Economic Power

Mon Oct 5 | State or Market? Competing Views of Economic Power

Reading / Activity: Friedrich A. Hayek, *The Road to Serfdom*, Ch. 3, "Individualism and Collectivism"; Karl Polanyi, *The Great Transformation*, Ch. 6, "The Self-Regulating Market and the Fictitious

Commodities: Labor, Land, and Money.” We will compare Hayek and Polanyi on whether political freedom is threatened more by state economic intervention or by socially disruptive markets.

Extended reading (optional): Sarah Gardner (2017), “From Hamilton to Trump, the U.S. Has a Long History of America-First Policies,” Marketplace.

Wed Oct 7 | MIDTERM EXAM

Reading / Activity: No new reading.

Due / Notes: Midterm Exam

Mon Oct 12 | NO CLASS - Fall Break

Reading / Activity: Classes suspended.

Wed Oct 14 | The Developmental State

Reading / Activity: Peter B. Evans (1989), “Predatory, Developmental, and Other Apparatuses: A Comparative Political Economy Perspective on the Third World State,” Sociological Forum 4 (entire article).

Extended reading (optional): Atul Kohli (2004), State-Directed Development: Political Power and Industrialization in the Global Periphery, Introduction, pp. 1-24.

Due / Notes: Game 2 Host Team Issue Background Brief due (4 points).

Mon Oct 19 | Globalization, Trade, and Economic Dependence

Reading / Activity: Joseph E. Stiglitz (2018), Globalization and Its Discontents Revisited, Introduction, pp. xv-xlv.

Extended reading (optional): Ronald Rogowski (1989), Commerce and Coalitions: How Trade Affects Domestic Political Alignments, Ch. 1, “Why Changing Exposure to Trade Should Affect Political Cleavages.”

Extended reading (optional): Albert O. Hirschman (1945; expanded ed. 1980), National Power and the Structure of Foreign Trade, Ch. 1, “Economic Thought on the Relationship Between Foreign Trade and National Power.”

Due / Notes: Quiz 3

Wed Oct 21 | STRATEGIC COMPETITION GAME 2 - Economic Power and Economic Statecraft

Reading / Activity: No new academic reading.

Due / Notes: Team C Host / Team D Guest

Part III - Military Power

Mon Oct 26 | Civil-Military Relations

Reading / Activity: Samuel P. Huntington (1995), “Armed Forces and Democracy: Reforming Civil-Military Relations,” Journal of Democracy 6(4); Richard H. Kohn (1997), “How Democracies Control the Military,” Journal of Democracy 8(4) (both entire articles). Class discussion will

examine civilian control, military professionalism, and how political leaders can keep armed forces effective while maintaining civilian authority.

Extended reading (optional): Peter D. Feaver (1996), "The Civil-Military Problematique: Huntington, Janowitz, and the Question of Civilian Control," *Armed Forces & Society* 23(2) (entire article).

Extended reading (optional): Barbara Geddes, Erica Frantz, and Joseph G. Wright (2014), "Military Rule," *Annual Review of Political Science* 17 (entire article).

Wed Oct 28 | THE FORUM - Dr. Khang Vu (Boston College)

Reading / Activity: Preparation reading to be selected with the speaker. Topic: From the Asia-Pacific to the Indo-Pacific; alliances, buck passing, abandonment, entrapment, and alliance security dilemma.

Extended reading (optional): Stephen M. Walt (1987), *The Origins of Alliances*, Ch. 2, "Explaining Alliance Formation," pp. 17-49.

Due / Notes: Game 3 Host Team Issue Background Brief due (4 points).

Mon Nov 2 | Why Do Wars Happen?

Reading / Activity: Tanisha M. Fazal and Paul Poast (2019), "War Is Not Over: What the Optimists Get Wrong About Conflict," *Foreign Affairs* 98(6) (entire article); Council on Foreign Relations (2026), "Iran's War With Israel and the United States," *Global Conflict Tracker*.

Extended reading (optional): Michael W. Doyle (1986), "Liberalism and World Politics," *American Political Science Review* 80(4) (entire article).

Due / Notes: Quiz 4

Wed Nov 4 | STRATEGIC COMPETITION GAME 3 - Military Power and Alliance Politics

Reading / Activity: No new academic reading.

Due / Notes: Team B Host / Team A Guest

Part IV - Institutional Power

Mon Nov 9 | Domestic Political Institutions

Reading / Activity: Juan J. Linz (1990), "The Perils of Presidentialism," *Journal of Democracy* 1(1) (entire article). We will compare presidential and parliamentary government and examine how institutional design can shape political conflict, representation, and democratic stability.

Extended reading (optional): John M. Carey (2021), "Did Trump Prove That Political Systems with Presidents Simply Don't Work?" *Washington Post* (entire article).

Due / Notes: Checkpoint 2 due, 11:59 p.m.; Game 4 Host Team Issue Background Brief due (4 points).

Wed Nov 11 | International Organizations: Can Rules Constrain Power?

Reading / Activity: United Nations (1945), *Charter of the United Nations*, Arts. 1-2 and 23-27; Robert O. Keohane (1998), "International Institutions: Can Interdependence Work?" *Foreign Policy* 110; Somini Sengupta (2017), "What Is the United Nations? Explaining Its Purpose, Power

and Problems,” New York Times. Read both articles in full. We will examine why states create international institutions and whether rules and institutions can constrain powerful states.

Extended reading (optional): G. John Ikenberry (2011), “The Future of the Liberal World Order: Internationalism After America,” Foreign Affairs 90(3) (entire article).

Due / Notes: Quiz 5

Mon Nov 16 | STRATEGIC COMPETITION GAME 4 - Institutional Power / Model UN

Reading / Activity: No new academic reading.

Due / Notes: Team D Host / Team C Guest

Research Conference

Wed Nov 18 | RESEARCH CONFERENCE I

Reading / Activity: No new reading.

Due / Notes: 4 student presentations

Mon Nov 23 | RESEARCH CONFERENCE II

Reading / Activity: No new reading.

Due / Notes: 4 student presentations

Wed Nov 25 | NO CLASS - Thanksgiving Break

Reading / Activity: Classes suspended.

Mon Nov 30 | RESEARCH CONFERENCE III

Reading / Activity: No new reading.

Due / Notes: 4 student presentations

Wed Dec 2 | RESEARCH CONFERENCE IV

Reading / Activity: No new reading.

Due / Notes: 3 student presentations

Conclusion

Mon Dec 7 | Who Has Power? Course Synthesis

Reading / Activity: No required reading. Final research paper due during the final exam period; exact date/time announced on Brightspace.